Does a hard 15-day run-up signal a new bull market?

Evaluating the claim: "sharp upward thrusts historically presage near-term bull markets — so why is this time different?"

Short answer: it's a valid question, but the premise is half-right.

Sharp run-ups **with confirming breadth** have an exceptional historical track record (Zweig / Whaley breadth thrusts: ~14–16 signals since 1945, every one higher 6 and 12 months later in most data sets). But sharp run-ups **without** breadth confirmation are exactly what bear-market rallies look like — and there are many of those too. The discriminator isn't the size of the rally; it's its *character*.

The bullish case for "rallies presage bulls"

The strongest version of the claim relies on **breadth thrusts** — sharp moves where almost every stock rallies, not just a few mega-caps. The most-cited is the Zweig Breadth Thrust (ZBT): the 10-day average ratio of advancing issues moves from oversold (under ~0.40) to euphoric (over ~0.615) in 10 trading days or fewer. It's rare and almost mechanically bullish.

~14–16	100%	~24%	3–4 mo
ZBT signals since 1945	Higher 6 & 12 mo later	Avg 12-month return	Median time to new high

Approximate figures from Ned Davis Research, Wayne Whaley, and Ryan Detrick studies; specifics vary by data set and the exact threshold used.

The bearish counter-case: violent rallies live inside bear markets

The single largest one-day S&P 500 gains in history almost all happened during bear markets, not new bulls. The 2000–2002 and 2007–2009 bears each contained multiple 10–20% multi-week rallies that completely failed. So a sharp 15-day move is, on its own, *more* common in bear markets than in fresh bulls — what's rare is the **kind** of sharp move.

- Oct 1929 → +35% rally → new low
- Apr 2001 → +19% → new low
- Mar 2008 (Bear Stearns) → +12% → new low
- Nov 2008 → +21% → Mar 2009 low
- Jun 2022 → +12% → Oct 2022 low
- Aug 2022 → +18% → Oct 2022 low

Side-by-side: what real thrusts vs. failed bounces looked like

Episode	Type	Breadth confirmed?	Catalyst	12 months later
Aug 1982	ZBT	Yes	Volcker pivot, recession ending	+44%
Jan 1987	ZBT	Yes	Earnings momentum	+22% (pre-crash)
Jan 1991	ZBT	Yes	Gulf War resolution, Fed easing	+30%
Mar–Apr 2009	ZBT	Yes	TARP/Fed backstop, capitulation low	+45%
Jun 2020	ZBT	Yes	Fed liquidity flood, reopen	+38%
Nov 2023	ZBT	Yes	Dovish Fed pivot, soft-landing data	+32%
Oct 1929	Sharp rally only	No	Reflexive bounce after crash	–54%
Apr 2001	Sharp rally only	No	Fed cuts, dot-com hopium	–18%
Nov 2008	Sharp rally only	Partial	Bailout headlines	+8% (after deeper low)
Jun & Aug 2022	Sharp rally only	No	Peak-inflation hopes	–4% to flat

"Breadth confirmed" means a real ZBT or Whaley up-volume thrust fired at the time. Returns rounded; figures from S&P 500 price index.

So what would tell you "this time is (or isn't) different"?

The honest answer to the user's question is: it's not "is this time different" — it's "which kind of run-up is this?" Five concrete diagnostics separate real thrusts from bear-market rallies:

1. Breadth participation

Did a ZBT or Whaley thrust actually trigger? Are 80%+ of stocks above their 50-day MA? If only the top 7 mega-caps moved while the equal-weight index lagged, it's narrow — that's the bear-market-rally fingerprint.

2. Volume character

Up-volume vs. down-volume on a 5- and 10-day basis. Real thrusts show up-volume swamping down-volume (Whaley's classic 9-to-1 up days clustered together). Short-cover-only rallies often don't.

3. Where it started from

Real bottoms come out of *capitulation* — VIX spikes above 35–40, AAII bulls below 25%, credit spreads blowing out. A run-up off a mild dip with sentiment never having truly puked is suspicious.

4. The catalyst's durability

A rally on a Fed pivot or earnings inflection is more durable than one on a reversible policy headline (tariff pause, geopolitical de-escalation). If the news that caused the rally can be undone by a tweet, so can the rally.

5. Confirmation from credit & rates

Bull markets are usually confirmed by tightening high-yield spreads and a steepening curve out of inversion. If equities rip but credit spreads stay wide or 2s/10s re-inverts, equities are out over their skis.

6. Follow-through 1–3 months out

The clearest tell is time. Real thrusts make a higher high within 1–3 months and don't retest the low. Failed rallies stall, roll over, and break the prior support within ~6–10 weeks.

What I can't tell you from here

I don't have a live market feed for late April 2026, so I can't tell you whether the current 15-day move actually triggered a ZBT, what breadth looks like, or whether credit is confirming. The framework above is the right way to *answer* "why is this time different" — plug in the live readings on those six diagnostics and the question collapses into a checklist instead of a vibe.

Bottom line for the original question

The premise — "sharp run-ups historically presage bull markets" — is **conditionally** true. It's true for breadth-confirmed thrusts (an exceptional record). It's not true for sharp rallies in general; those are at least as common inside bear markets as at the start of bulls. So the right reframing of the question isn't "why is this time different?" — it's "is this run-up the rare breadth-thrust kind, or the common bear-market-rally kind?" That's an empirically answerable question, not a narrative one.